Mixing or Moving? Segregation, Gentrification and the Renewal of the Waterloo Estate

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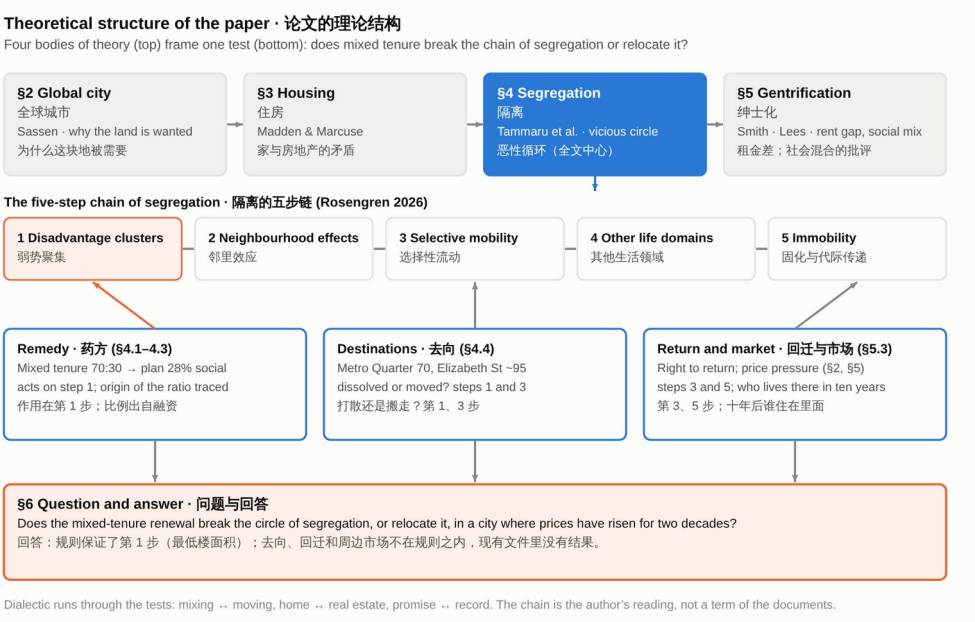


Figure 0. Theoretical structure: four bodies of theory frame one test of the chain of segregation.

1. Introduction

Mixing tenures is a standard remedy for the concentration of disadvantage in public housing estates. The NSW Government justified renewing its estates with a diagnosis, that disadvantage clusters in estates and is "passed on through multiple generations" (NSW Government 2016, PDF p. 24), and with a remedy, a 70:30 split between private and social dwellings "to enable more integrated communities" (NSW Government 2016, PDF p. 9). This paper asks whether the renewal of the Waterloo estate in Sydney breaks that circle of segregation or only moves it, and argues that the approved plan dilutes the estate, while whether it breaks the circle depends on tenants returning, which the planning documents do not secure: they set minimum floor areas for social housing and state relocation and return only as intentions.

Waterloo, with about 2,000 dwellings on 18 hectares, is among Sydney's largest inner-city public housing estates (Chatterjee et al. 2018), and its renewal has been described as the largest estate renewal proposed in Australia to date (Zanardo et al. 2024, 1208). The plan has changed several times since the state government announced it in 2015. The planning route, which decides what the rules can fix, moved from a state-led process to a council-led one in

2019 (Turner Studio & Turf 2020, PDF p. 6) and back to the state in 2021 (NSW Department of Planning and Environment 2022, PDF p. 11).

The renewal takes place in an expensive and unequal market. Sydney's council, arguing for more affordable housing at Green Square Town Centre, describes "a growing disconnect between affluent households able to afford private market housing and highly socio-economically disadvantaged households living in inner city public housing estates" (City of Sydney n.d.). In that market the median price of attached dwellings more than doubled between 2006 and 2026 (Australian Bureau of Statistics 2026), and the sale of private dwellings funds the renewal (Zanardo et al. 2024, 1208).

Existing work on Waterloo concerns reputation and displacement. Zanardo et al. (2024, 1236) and Sisson (2024) describe a reputational gap, a term Yrjänä (2026) attributes to Kallin, in which the present of a place is devalued and its imagined potential is set against it, and Wynne and Rogers (2021) show how residents experience the threat of displacement before any demolition. This paper takes reputation as background and reads the plan against the five steps of the vicious circle of segregation.

The paper is a document analysis. Its materials are the planning documents for Waterloo South (the plan finalisation report, the final planning proposal and the Design Guide, all from 2022) and for the concept application of 2025–26 (the proponent's scoping report, the issued assessment requirements, the exhibition notice and appendices A–E of the impact statement), government statements and media releases from 2015 to 2026, news reports, the 2020 social baseline report and census figures for Waterloo, and published studies of Waterloo and of estates elsewhere in Australia and the United States. Each protection for tenants is sorted by where it appears: in a binding planning control, in the Design Guide, in a statement inside the planning record, or only in an announcement.

The argument has three steps. First, the plan changes the tenure mix on the site, and binding minimum floor areas secure that change (section 4). Second, the tenants it moves appear in the documents examined only through promises of return and support, with no count and no follow-up, and where return has been counted elsewhere, between 5 and about 40 per cent of tenants came back (section 4). Third, the market around the estate was already changing the neighbourhood, so the plan adds private housing to the estate where the market had added it around it (sections 4 and 5). The sections take four bodies of urban theory in turn: the global city, housing, segregation and gentrification.

2. The global city: why Waterloo is drawn into the dispute

The strategy that frames Sydney as a global city does not name Waterloo. The state's 2014 metropolitan strategy defines a Global Economic Corridor that "generates over 41 per cent of the NSW Gross State Product" and lists Green Square among its strategic centres, in line with the global-city idea that a city's competitiveness rests on central land, infrastructure and the services of a global economy (Sassen 1991; NSW Planning and Environment 2014, 44). So the question for the renewal is what happens to the people already living on the land.

The renewal is paid for by selling new private flats, so the price those flats can fetch matters, and that price has risen strongly. The median transfer price of attached dwellings in Sydney rose from $390,000 in June 2006 to $840,000 in June 2026, and that of houses from $495,000

to $1,487,600 (Australian Bureau of Statistics 2026; Figure 1). The documents examined give no price or rent figures for the Waterloo site itself.



Figure 1. Sydney's median transfer prices rose strongly between 2006 and 2026.

What brought the pressure to Waterloo was a metro station. The urban design study for Waterloo South calls the station "the catalyst for the renewal" (Turner Studio & Turf 2020, Part 1, PDF p. 6), and the planning proposal argues that keeping the site as it is would ignore "the potential catalytic effects of the new Metro station" (NSW Land and Housing Corporation [LAHC] 2020, 92). So the pressure arrived through a transport investment and not through the global-city strategy. The reason given for replacing the housing is a different one. Future Directions, a statewide strategy, says that "many estates experience high levels of crime, unemployment, domestic violence, tenancy management problems, poor educational outcomes and associated child protection issues" (NSW Government 2016, PDF p. 24). This describes estates in general, not Waterloo, and section 4 tests it.

3. Housing: the strategy, and the conflict between home and real estate

From the start the plan has treated Waterloo both as people's homes and as a way to pay for new housing. In December 2015 the state announced that the estate would be demolished and rebuilt with about 30 per cent social and 70 per cent private housing, the sale of the private dwellings funding the project (Zanardo et al. 2024, 1208), in line with a statewide target of 70:30 (NSW Government 2016, PDF p. 9). The planning proposal says the existing properties are "at the end of their economic life" (LAHC 2020, 23), yet the same study gives their average age as 44 years against a benchmark life of 60 (Turner Studio & Turf 2020, Part 1, PDF p. 6). Madden and Marcuse (2016) call this tension a conflict between home and real estate: housing as lived, social space against housing as an instrument for profit-making.

The promises to tenants grew after 2023, but the planning rules were written before them (Figure 2). The plan approved in 2022 provides 3,012 dwellings, of which 847 are social housing, and its planning controls date from November 2022 (NSW Department of Planning and Environment 2022, PDF p. 37). After a change of government in March 2023, the share of social and affordable housing across the estate was raised from 34 to 50 per cent, tenants were promised the right to return, and relocation was to proceed in small stages (NSW Government 2023). In 2024 it added at least six months' notice and dedicated support (NSW Government 2024). By 2026 a new concept application proposed about 3,300 homes, at least half of them social or affordable (Scully 2026). So the promises moved ahead of the rules.

The floor-area part has since reached the planning documents: the proponent's 2025 scoping report describes 50 per cent of residential floor area as committed to social and affordable housing (Beam Planning 2025, PDF pp. 4, 20), and the 2026 concept application proposes at least 30 per cent of residential floor area as social housing and no more than 50 per cent as market housing (NSW Department of Planning, Housing and Infrastructure 2026). None of the three documents for this stage mentions a right of return.

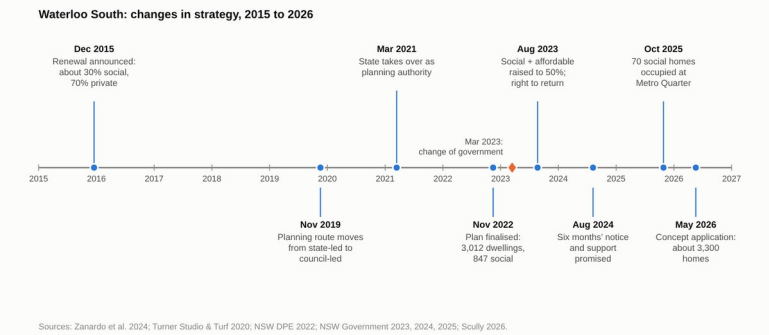


Figure 2. The strategy for Waterloo South changed several times between 2015 and 2026.

The strategy can be sorted into measures that protect the money and measures that protect the tenants' homes. On the money side, the planning proposal says that the existing planning rules "would not be capable of supporting a feasible redevelopment of the entire site given the costs of demolition and construction" (LAHC 2020, 92) and the sale of private dwellings carries the cost. On the tenants' side are the right to return, and more social homes in Waterloo South than there are now (Homes NSW 2026). No official document sorts the strategy in this way. Sections 4.5 and 4.6 ask which side the binding rules protect.

4. Segregation: testing the remedy against the chain

The state's case for renewal rests on an argument that segregation research also makes: disadvantage that clusters in one place reproduces itself. Tammaru et al. (2021) describe vicious circles of segregation as the product of connected social and spatial inequalities in different life domains: advantage breeds advantage and disadvantage breeds disadvantage. Five steps can be distinguished (Figure 3): disadvantage clusters spatially, neighbourhood effects follow, poor perceptions shape who moves, segregation spreads to other domains such as schools and work, and it becomes immobility across the life course and across generations (Rosengren 2026). Future Directions follows the same chain. It finds disadvantage concentrated in estates, says that its effects "can be passed on through multiple generations, reinforcing the cycle of disadvantage" (NSW Government 2016, PDF p. 24), and proposes mixed tenure, with a 70:30 split between private and social dwellings "to enable more integrated communities" (PDF p. 9).

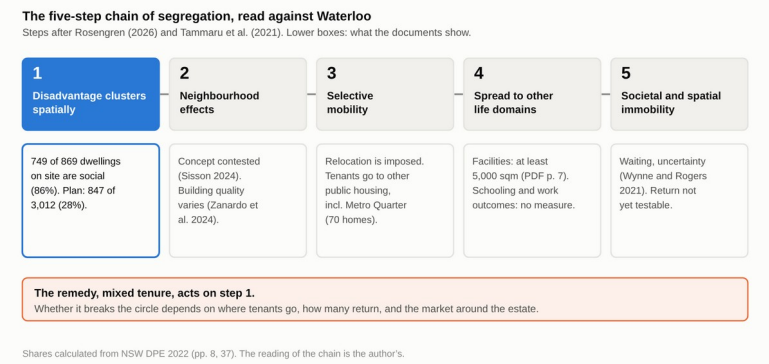


Figure 3. The five-step chain of segregation, read against Waterloo: mixed tenure acts on step 1.

On step 1 the plan works: social housing falls from 86 per cent of the site's dwellings to 28 per cent. Waterloo South now has 749 social and 120 private dwellings, and the approved plan has 847 social dwellings among 3,012 (NSW Department of Planning and Environment 2022, PDF pp. 8, 37; shares calculated from these figures; Figure 4). This is dilution by social mixing, which makes concentrated disadvantage less visible. The same plan can also be described as growth, 847 social dwellings against 749, so a document can call it dilution or growth depending on whether it counts share or number. Either way, step 1 is the part of the remedy that the planning rules fix (section 4.5).

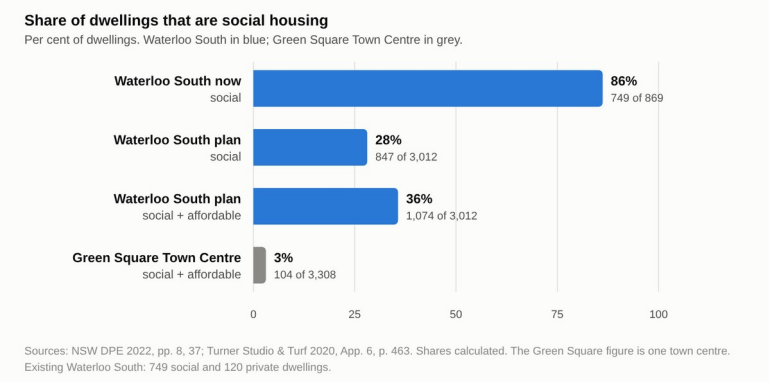


Figure 4. The share of social housing at Waterloo South falls from about 86 to about 28 per cent in the plan; Green Square Town Centre is shown for comparison.

Who lives on the site shapes what step 1 dilutes. In September 2019 the 749 social dwellings of Waterloo South housed households with an average income of $525 a week; the heads of 68 per cent were over 50, 73 per cent lived alone, and 33 per cent drew their main income from a disability pension (GHD 2020, PDF pp. 30, 34). In the 2016 census Indigenous people were 9 per cent of the Waterloo South area, 3 per cent of the suburb and 1 per cent of the City of Sydney, and one-parent families were 35 per cent of its families, against 15 and 10 per cent (GHD 2020, PDF pp. 32, 34). Its neighbourhoods ranked in the two lowest deciles of disadvantage in the state, against the eighth for the City of Sydney (GHD 2020, PDF p. 30). The concentration is therefore mostly one of age, disability and living alone. Steps 4 and 5 of the chain concern schools, work and the next generation, and at most a third of the households have a head under 50.

The area around the estate has already been mixed by the market. The social baseline report says that the surroundings "have undergone significant redevelopment in recent years", which

“changed local demographics, with more tertiary students, … professionals, young families, couples without children” (GHD 2020, PDF p. 3). Most neighbourhoods of Waterloo East rank in the eighth decile of advantage or higher, “which could be attributed to the renewed areas of the suburb” (PDF p. 30), and the report expects the renewal of Waterloo South to be “highly likely to attract a similar demographic” (PDF p. 31). The median household income of the suburb rose from $1,503 a week in the 2016 census to $2,028 in 2021, a nominal rise of about 35 per cent (GHD 2020, PDF p. 35; Australian Bureau of Statistics 2021). That figure covers private households as well as tenants and does not describe the estate. None of the documents examined gives incomes on the estate after 2019.

The chain also runs at the scale of the whole city, and the remedy acts on the estate. In Greater Sydney the large social-housing estates that dominate a disadvantaged suburb lie mainly in the western suburbs: of 177 disadvantaged suburbs in Sydney, Melbourne and Brisbane, 14 are dominated by social housing and 13 of those are in Sydney (Hulse et al. 2014, PDF pp. 16, 40). Waterloo is not one of them. The same study had to set aside Waterloo and Haymarket as statistical outliers, Waterloo for “rapid gentrification” (PDF p. 38). The latest metropolitan study finds Sydney’s segregation rising because very-high-income households cluster in the least disadvantaged areas “rather than” because very-low-income households cluster (Sarkar et al. 2024, PDF p. 34). The state’s metropolitan plan lists “areas of high social housing concentration where there is good access to services, transport and jobs” as candidates for renewal (Greater Sydney Commission 2018, PDF p. 61), which points renewal at well-served locations such as Waterloo’s. Pawson, Hulse and Cheshire (2015, PDF p. 12) call the use of local solutions for systemic causes a “scalar mismatch”. Renewing Waterloo can therefore reduce concentration on the estate without changing the metropolitan pattern. No study that was found follows where inner-city tenants go across Sydney; the one statement available, for Millers Point, is that most were settled within 10 km of the city centre (Morris 2017, PDF p. 7).

The 70:30 remedy was not designed from evidence about what mixing achieves. Khor et al. (2023, 77), citing Darcy and Rogers (2019), trace the ratio to Bonnyrigg, a suburban estate, where social-mixing outcomes “was not a determinant of decision-making”, and Shrestha, Ruming and Rogers (2025) find that Sydney’s estate-renewal models have moved “from periphery, through middle ring, towards core”. So a remedy first used on suburban estates has now reached the inner city. None of these sources counts returning tenants or measures neighbourhood effects. That outcomes were not a determinant fits the financialisation of housing (Aalbers 2016), in which housing is treated as an asset, and the rules then enforce a quantity of tenure and not an outcome.

Where displaced tenants go decides whether the cluster is dissolved or only moved. Current tenants have moved into other public housing, at least 70 of them into the new homes beside the Waterloo metro station (Bowring 2026). The government names two local destinations, the 70 social homes at the Metro Quarter and about 95 more at Elizabeth Street, Redfern (Homes NSW 2026), and in 2023 it presented Elizabeth Street as a way to rehouse Waterloo South tenants locally (NSW Government 2023; Figure 5). What can be said is that the plan dilutes social housing on the site while also placing social housing nearby.

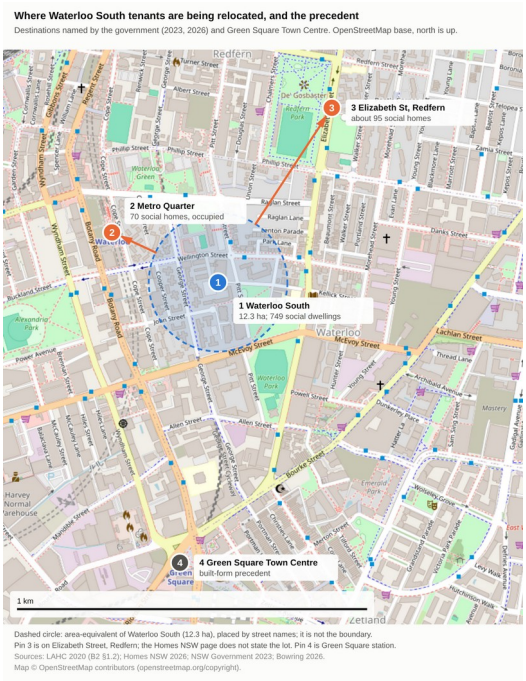


Figure 5. Where Waterloo South tenants are being relocated: the Metro Quarter and Elizabeth Street, Redfern are the destinations named by the government; Green Square Town Centre is the precedent.

The planning rules guarantee how much social housing is built, but not who lives in it and not whether tenants can come back. The site-specific controls that the plan finalisation report lists for Waterloo South require no less than 26.5 per cent of residential floor area as social housing, no less than 7.0 per cent as affordable housing, and at least 5,000 square metres for community, health and childcare facilities (NSW Department of Planning and Environment 2022, PDF p. 7). These are minimum amounts of floor area. If a person's relation to housing shapes their class position, as housing class theory holds (Ruonavaara 2025), such minimums fix which kinds of housing the new buildings contain, not which households hold them. The Design Guide, where the tenure and Aboriginal housing provisions sit, is only to be considered in development applications "but not to elevate the guidance within the design guide to development standards" (PDF p. 7). Its principle that social and affordable housing be provided "so that a socially diverse residential population, representative of all income groups, is created" (Hassell 2022b, PDF p. 22) comes closest to the people the housing is for, and it does not mention return.

Return and relocation appear only as statements. The final planning proposal records that the Land and Housing Corporation "has noted" that current residents have a right of return (Hassell 2022a, PDF p. 59), and in assessing the rezoning the department accepted a response stating that "appropriate relocation strategies will be developed" (NSW Department of Planning and Environment 2022, PDF p. 14). The report adds that state significant developments must include a social impact assessment (PDF p. 31), which is done when applying, and neither document requires anyone to track what happens to tenants after they move. These controls are also changing: a 2025 proposal would amend the Sydney local plan by "introducing flexibility to the application of the design guide" (NSW Department of Planning, Housing and Infrastructure 2025a, 1), and the exhibition notice of May 2026 lists further amendments (NSW Department of Planning, Housing and Infrastructure 2026). The

requirements issued in October 2025 ask for a Social Impact Assessment and a Preliminary Social Impact Management Plan, without naming relocation or return (NSW Department of Planning, Housing and Infrastructure 2025b, PDF p. 9). The impact statement lodged for that application in April 2026 adds measures of the same kind. Its mitigation measures, listed for later detailed applications, say that "current social housing residents are to be supported during relocations" (Beam Planning 2026, App. C, PDF p. 11), and its consultation table records "relocation certainty" among community concerns (App. D, PDF p. 1). Neither says return, and neither sets a count or a follow-up. The body of the impact statement, the social impact assessment (its Appendix EE) and the gazetted rules are outside this reading (section 6.4). In terms of the five steps, the rules reach step 1 and, through the facilities, the services side of step 4. Steps 3 and 5, which concern where people go and what happens to them, depend on promises outside the rules (Table 1).

Table 1. The measures protecting Waterloo South tenants and housing, sorted by where they sit in the planning documents read (2022 versions, with the 2025–26 additions).

Measure	Where it sits	Source
Social housing: no less than 26.5% of residential floor area	Binding site-specific control	DPE 2022, PDF p. 7
Affordable housing: no less than 7.0% of residential floor area	Binding site-specific control	DPE 2022, PDF p. 7
Community, health and childcare facilities: no less than 5,000 sqm	Binding site-specific control	DPE 2022, PDF p. 7
Affordable housing in perpetuity; a socially diverse population; Aboriginal housing provisions	Design Guide (to be considered, not a development standard)	Hassell 2022b, PDF p. 22; DPE 2022, PDF p. 7
Right of return	Statement in the planning record ("has noted"), and announcements	Hassell 2022a, PDF p. 59; NSW Government 2023, 2024
Relocation strategy	Statement ("will be developed")	DPE 2022, PDF p. 14
Six months' notice; staged relocation	Announcement only, outside the planning documents read	NSW Government 2023, 2024
Floor-area shares in the 2026 concept: social at least 30%, market at most 50%, the rest affordable	Proposed in the concept application (on exhibition May–June 2026)	DPHI 2026
Social Impact Assessment and Preliminary Social Impact Management Plan	Requirement for the concept application (assessment requirements, October 2025)	DPHI 2025b, PDF p. 9

Where return has been counted elsewhere, it has been low. About 40 per cent of residents came back to Carlton in Melbourne, after being moved first to other estates or to dwellings elsewhere, and 20 per cent to Kensington (Porter et al. 2023, 30, citing Levin et al. 2018 and Shaw et al. 2013). In Chicago, fewer than 11 per cent of the 16,846 relocated family households lived in the new mixed-income developments at the end of 2010 (Joseph and Chaskin 2012, 378), and the average return rate at four HOPE VI sites was 5 per cent (Comey 2007, cited in Joseph and Chaskin 2012, 379). Goetz (2010) concludes that "so few return, in fact, that it makes little sense to list the redevelopment itself as one of the benefits for original residents", and ties this to the years between displacement and completion and to new screening criteria. Bonnyrigg in Sydney is the closest model, since staged building let tenants move within the estate, and Porter et al. (2023, 30) expect Waterloo to follow it. Bonnyrigg

still lost about 200 social dwellings (Porter et al. 2023, 30), whereas the Waterloo South plan raises the number from 749 to 847. The Bonnyrigg panel study warns that where tenants are moved off an estate with a right of return, “there has often been an inevitable tendency” for them to stay where they were placed, so that “the community is quite different” (Pinnegar, Liu and Randolph 2013, 50). These are other cities and other programmes, and none gives a Waterloo figure.

Steps 2 to 5 are where the evidence is thinnest. Sisson (2024) notes that the concept of neighbourhood effects behind “concentrated disadvantage” “controversially” places the cause in the estate. Hirvonen and Lilius (2019), in a Finnish survey, find only small differences in neighbour ties between house types and a need to develop social ties “also in rental houses”, which suggests that contact across tenures has to be built and does not follow from proximity; the survey is Finnish and does not address mixed tenure. Reviews offer limited evidence on steps 2 to 5: a systematic review of 27 UK studies found some positive effects of mixed tenure in the social and residential domains but none on social capital (Sautkina, Bond and Kearns 2012), and Manley, van Ham and Doherty (2011) conclude that the evidence base for social mixing is “far from robust”. Uncertainty already acts on steps three and five. Wynne and Rogers (2021) argue that the threat of eviction “has already done significant damage to their relationship to place” before any move, and a resident, Julie, said that she heard of the demolition work when she woke to find fences going up, and that her relocation had been delayed (Bowring 2026). Read through the chain, residents neither choose nor time their moves, and the wait is part of the circle. No document measures residents’ mobility or opportunities.

5. Gentrification: price, cost and promise

Tenants can lose their homes in two ways, and the promise of return covers only one of them. Gentrification research asks who gains when land is reinvested in and who bears the cost. Smith’s rent gap is the disparity between potential ground rent and the rent capitalised under the present use (Smith 1979), and Stein describes gentrification as “planned by the state, produced by the developers and consumed by the condo crowd” (Stein 2019, 41). One way is through the market around an estate: Atkinson et al. (2011, 10) found for Sydney and Melbourne that displacement from gentrified neighbourhoods ran at about one and a half times the out-movement of similar households elsewhere, and that the most vulnerable displaced households were private renters, in data from the 2000s. The other way is direct: the estate’s own tenants are moved by their landlord, and the promise of return addresses only this second way. None of the planning documents examined addresses the first.

Mixing is the policy that this remedy shares with “positive gentrification”, and the evidence for it is weak. Lees (2008) finds a “poor evidence base” for that policy, which is promoted in the belief that it will reduce segregation. Yrjänä (2026) shows in Helsinki how an anti-segregation policy can serve state-led gentrification, with a subsidy gap in which the state pays the difference to de-risk private investment. Hochstenbach (2017) finds for Amsterdam that the instruments of social mixing moved from the renewal of declining post-war neighbourhoods to high-demand neighbourhoods where housing policy pushes gentrification, the direction that Shrestha, Ruming and Rogers (2025) trace in Sydney. Davidson (2018, 249), reading new-build gentrification as large-scale capital working with state power, adds

that the state “has been required to provide justifications for its actions”; for Waterloo the justification offered is the statewide diagnosis of section 4. In the 2022 planning proposal, residential floor area on Land and Housing Corporation sites was split 26.5 per cent social, 7.0 per cent affordable and 66.5 per cent market (Hassell 2022a, PDF p. 19). The 2026 concept application proposes at least 30 per cent social housing and no more than 50 per cent market housing, with the balance affordable (NSW Department of Planning, Housing and Infrastructure 2026). The sale of private dwellings funds the project (section 3), so the market share is the part that pays for the rest, and that share has fallen from two thirds to at most a half as the policy changed. Whether this dilutes the cluster or prepares the area for richer residents, the documents do not show.

On paper tenants are better protected than in 2015, but most of the protections are promises and not rules. They include the right to return, six months’ notice, staged relocation, more social homes and a share for Aboriginal households (NSW Government 2023, 2024; Homes NSW 2026). Of these, the right to return, notice and staging are not among the site-specific controls listed in the plan finalisation report (NSW Department of Planning and Environment 2022, PDF p. 7). The plan replaces 749 social dwellings with 847, an increase of 98 (NSW Department of Planning and Environment 2022, PDF pp. 8, 37; difference calculated), and under the previous government’s plan for the whole estate Sisson and Ruming (2025, 1839) calculated a net gain of 148, an uplift of 7 per cent. The minister could not say what part of the 20 per cent affordable share would be permanent (Bowring 2026). The applicant’s 2026 assessment of the Design Guide says that at least 7 per cent of residential floor area will be affordable housing held in perpetuity by a community housing provider and any further affordable housing for a minimum of 25 years, and expects these requirements to be imposed as conditions of consent on later applications (Beam Planning 2026, App. E, PDF p. 6). No figures are published on how many tenants return or how soon. The question is therefore not whether the new buildings will exist but who will live in them and near them in ten years’ time. The documents promise return and do not show it.

6. Conclusion and discussion

The approved plan mixes the site, and the planning rules secure only the mixing. Social housing falls from 86 to 28 per cent of the dwellings on the site, and binding minimum floor areas guarantee that step 1 of the chain is addressed. Whether the circle is broken or only moved is decided by what the rules do not cover: where the displaced tenants live, how many return, and what the market around the estate does. The evidence here shows some tenants placed in other social housing nearby and return promised to the rest, in a market where gentrification has widened the gap between households in private housing and in public housing estates (City of Sydney n.d.). The planning documents do not show whether the circle is broken or only moved, and where return has been counted in other cities it has been low (section 4).

This paper adds three small things to existing work on Waterloo. First, it reads the renewal through the chain of segregation. Four studies of Waterloo (Zanardo et al. 2024; Sisson 2024; Wynne and Rogers 2021; Sisson and Ruming 2025) deal with reputation, land value, displacement and housing supply, and none of them uses the vocabulary of segregation. Second, it sorts each protection for tenants by where it sits in the planning documents (Table

1) and finds that the rules guarantee floor area while return and relocation are statements. Third, it separates two things that are often run together: a plan can be described as dilution or as growth depending on whether it counts share or number, and tenants can lose their homes through the market around an estate or directly through their landlord, and only the second is covered by the promise of return.

The case supports some frameworks and limits others. It is consistent with the view of Stein and Davidson that the state plans and justifies large-scale redevelopment (Davidson 2018, 249), and it extends the global-city account by showing that the pressure reached Waterloo through a metro station and not through the strategy that frames the corridor. It limits two accounts. In Yrjänä's (2026) Helsinki the state pays a subsidy gap to de-risk private investment, while in the Waterloo documents the money runs the other way, with private sales paying for social homes. And accounts of home against real estate (Madden and Marcuse 2016), or of mixing against segregation, treat the two sides as opposed, while Waterloo's policy has kept changing: the share of social and affordable housing rose from 34 to 50 per cent in 2023 (NSW Government 2023), the right to return was added, and a 2025 proposal would loosen how the Design Guide applies (NSW Department of Planning, Housing and Infrastructure 2025a, 1).

This argument has limits. It rests on documents and published studies, not on interviews, so residents' experience comes through other researchers and single news reports. The body of the environmental impact statement, the social impact assessment, the gazetted rules and the Homes NSW relocation policy were not read (of the impact statement only appendices A to E were), so "not among the rules" means only that a measure is not in the documents examined, and the finding may change if the exhibited documents write return into the rules. Shrestha, Ruming and Rogers (2025) and Hochstenbach (2017) are known here from their abstracts. Destinations are named but not counted, and no source gives the number of Waterloo tenants who have returned or the incomes of those who live on the estate now; the figures on return come from other cities, where tenure, programme and period differ. The price and income series are for the suburb or the city, not the estate. The documents do not use the five-step chain; it is the frame applied to them, and no study applying it to Sydney, or following inner-city tenants' destinations across the metropolitan area, was found. No official document explains the land-value funding model. The conclusion therefore holds for the documents examined and may change when the exhibited proposal is read in full.

Planning could do for people what it already does for floor space. The rules fix floor space by tenure; they could also require reporting on how many tenants return, when, and to the same place or only the same area, and where those who do not return live. The share of social housing should be published beside the number of social homes, because the number rises while the share falls. The permanence of the affordable homes beyond the first 7 per cent, which the applicant says will be held in perpetuity, should be confirmed. Where the existing buildings can be renovated, retention should be considered (Zanardo et al. 2024). None of this assumes bad faith. It asks that the cost of the remedy to the people it is meant to help be counted.

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